A commentary on the essence of

The Jewel Ornament of Liberation

of Dharma Lord Gampopa

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Introduction, Part 1

I. Overview

Gampopa's Life & Work

1. Gampopa's book lays out the whole path to buddahood.

2. Study and understand — then practice; without practice we can't digest the teachings.

3. The noble Dharma is not outside us, not hidden — it is within the mind.

4. The world's wars, famines, climate problems all manifest from our own confusion.

5. Resolving the problem within the mind — that is what Dharma practice means.

6. Calm abiding and special insight give us the opportunity to uproot mental confusion.

7. One who studies, understands and practices is rich, not in wealth, but in wisdom and contentment.

II. Paying Homage

To the Three Jewels, and to the lamas who are their foundation.

1. Homage to the Buddha, who purified all confusion and found unafflicted peace.

2. Homage to the Dharma, the teaching by which he reached that peace.

3. Homage to the Sangha, those great practitioners.

4. Gampopa wrote this book out of his teachers' kindness, for our benefit.

5. Gampopa bows to Manjushri so we may develop the wisdom that cuts ignorance.

6. Homage is paid to the Three Jewels because in samsara there is no other refuge.

7. Homage to the lamas who are the foundation of the buddhas and their followers.

8. Gampopa wrote this book depending on the kindness of Milarepa and Atisha, for our benefit.

III. Introduction — Written by Gampopa

It deals with a very important point: why do we practice Dharma?

1. This introduction here has a very important point: we should understand why we need to study and practice dharma.

2. All phenomena fall into two: samsara and nirvana — both empty by nature.

3. Empty means no independent entity: everything is illusory, changing, never staying by itself.

4. Samsara is a confused mental formation/projection; its defining characteristic is suffering.

5. For example, we think, "myself, something independent, exists." But when we investigate we cannot find it. Not having realized that, we grasp at a self as real and permanent, we cherish it so much and we suffer because of that.

6. Nirvana is all confused projections exhausted and dissipated: freedom from all suffering.

7. It is very important that we reflect on this first: confusion is what we have to purify.

8. When we say exhausting our confusion, it means exhausting all our mental afflictions: ignorance, attachment, aversion, pride, jealousy, self-grasping.

9. Then, after exhaustion, the leftover habits also need to be dissipated, because we are so habituated. Even though we may realize emptiness, there is still a habit of grasping. That needs to be purified too.

10. The defining characteristic of exhaustion and dissipation of confusion is freedom from all sufferings: suffering no longer exists, there is no cause of suffering.

11. Our interest is to be free from suffering and to achieve peace and happiness. This is the why we practice.

IV. Some Clarifications about Confusion

The basis & cause of confusion.

1. Who is it that is confused in samsara? All sentient beings of the three realms — desire, form, and formless — are confused.

2. On what basis does confusion arise? Confusion arises on the basis of emptiness — not that emptiness is the cause, but that we are confused about emptiness.

3. For example, we grasp at this body of ours as one whole, complete, independent thing, so attached to it that we do everything just to feed this ego-attachment.

4. What causes confusion to arise? The cause of confusion is great ignorance. Because of ignorance, I hold on to self-grasping, believing that a self exists within me; I cherish it so much and I suffer because of that.

5. We need to realize there is no independent self — for example that my body is just interdependent, arising from many causes and conditions. When we realize that, we see it as just a manifestation: not so much attachment, and no aversion when negative things happen.

6. Our study and practice is so important to purify our ignorance.

V. How Does Confusion Operate?

The complete picture of samsara

1. How does this confusion operate? It operates through the activities and experiences of the six realms of migrators.

2. Because of ignorance we have confusion; through that confusion we create karma, different layers of causes. Because of the different causes and conditions we have created, there arise the six realms in samsara.

3. For example, sometimes the mind is so heavily negative that the result is the hell realm — not necessarily a hell realm somewhere else; within our own life we sometimes experience something like hell-realm suffering.

4. Even in the human realm we can have all six of these experiences: hell-realm suffering, hungry-ghost suffering, animal suffering, human birth-and-death suffering, and the suffering of the demigods and gods.

5. What exemplifies this confusion? Confusion is like sleep and dream. When our mind falls asleep it becomes totally dark and forgets everything — that darkness is like ignorance. Then from that comes the dream.

6. In the dream we have many different experiences. Likewise, ignorance is a darkness of understanding regarding causality: through that ignorance we create different types of karma, and then, like a dream, we go through different types of suffering in the six realms.

7. When did this confusion originate? This confusion originated in beginningless samsara — there is no beginning and no end; it is a complete cycle. Like space, like the universe, it has no beginning.

VI. The Error of Confusion

Brief contemplation

1. Gampopa says "What is the error of the confusion? All the experiences in samsara are suffering". We may say life in samsara is sometimes very joyful — good weather, a good place to live, enjoying with family. Of course we cannot deny that. But it is not permanent.

2. For example, I am getting old. Everyone I know is getting older, many are getting sick, many are dying. They write to me, and I see very precisely what this means: I understand the pain.

3. The joy, peace and happiness we have in samsara is called the suffering of change — even joy, happiness, peace, a luxurious life can change; they do not stay as they are.

4. We are not making samsara something bad. Samsara is beautiful. But we have to understand its reality nature.

5. When does this confusion become transformed into primordial wisdom? When one attains unsurpassable enlightenment — that means buddhahood.

6. Within Buddhahood, the Dharmakaya. When one actualizes the Dharmakaya, then all these confusions... there is nothing but wisdom.

7. The nature of confusion is emptiness. When you realize the nature of confusion as emptiness, then primordial wisdom is percieved or achieved.

8. For this we need to study and practice the Dharma.